



The Rule as Told, the Rule as Kept

An Interview Study of How Households Enforce, Bend, and Quietly Redraw Their Own Phones-in-the-Basket Dinner Rule

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Abstract. A household's dinner-table phone rule is usually described as a fixed thing: phones go in a basket, a bowl, a drawer, until the meal ends. We conducted semi-structured interviews with 34 households that named such a rule unprompted, opening each interview by asking a participant to recite the rule as they would explain it to a visitor, then working back through the preceding fortnight's dinners for the exceptions that recitation left out. Thematic coding of 212 exception episodes across the sample sorted into four enforcement pathways, the largest of which — an exception granted without either party naming the rule at all — accounted for close to half of all coded episodes, more than any other single pathway. Comparing each household's opening recitation against its reconstructed fortnight of practice found the two matched in barely a quarter of households; most had drifted, almost always toward a looser practice than the stated rule described, and almost never through a conversation either party could date. We discuss what an unmarked drift of this kind suggests about the durability of a household rule's own language, and where the School's broader interest in priorities that outlive their original wording might usefully turn next.

Introduction

Ask a household with school-aged children whether they have a rule about phones at dinner, and most will answer immediately, often with a physical prop: a basket by the fridge, a bowl on the sideboard, a drawer that closes. The rule, as recited, sounds settled — a fixed threshold a phone crosses or doesn't. What that recitation is a description of, though, is rarely tested against the household's own recent dinners. Survey work on household technology rules typically asks whether a rule exists and how strict it is rated on a scale [1], [2]; observational work on a parent's device use around children counts phones present or in hand without asking what a household would say its own rule permits [3], [4]. Between the stated rule and the counted phone sits a great deal of everyday negotiation that neither method is built to capture: the exception nobody names, the exception both parties argue over, the exception a rule quietly absorbs until it is no longer really an exception.

Institutional theory has a name for a structure whose formal description no longer tracks what an organisation actually does: a formal structure can be adopted for its legitimacy while daily activity stays only loosely coupled to it, or decouples from it entirely, without the gap ever being formally acknowledged [5], [6], [7]. A household rule is a much smaller unit of governance than the ones that literature was built to describe, but the same distinction — what is said to be the rule, and what is actually enforced — has, to our knowledge, not been examined at the scale of the dinner table.

We make three contributions, each appropriately modest for a first qualitative pass. First, we develop a four-category taxonomy of how a household's phones-in-the-basket exceptions actually get handled, built from interview material rather than survey report. Second, we show the taxonomy's categories are unevenly populated, with unspoken accommodation doing more of the work than either formal renegotia-

tion or simple non-enforcement. Third, we compare each household's stated rule against its reconstructed practice and find the two diverge in most households, typically without either party marking the divergence as a change.

Related work

Meal-time device use has an established observational literature: caregivers and children on their phones during restaurant meals [3], parents texting while supervising children at the playground [4], and a broader review of how a parent's own device use reshapes parent-child interaction more generally [8]. This literature counts device presence and predicts downstream outcomes — interference in couple relationships [9], a drop in perceived conversation quality when a phone is merely visible [10], reduced attentiveness even when the phone stays untouched [11] — but treats the household's own stated rule, where one exists, as background rather than data.

A separate literature on family mealtime treats the meal itself as a site where household norms are enacted and transmitted: dinner-table talk as a structuring practice in its own right [12], and ritual mealtime elements as carriers of family identity independent of what gets said about them [13]. Neither asks what a household would recite as its own rule, nor whether the recitation holds up.

The closest instrument precedent is parental-mediation research, which scores how strictly a household polices children's technology use via structured questionnaire [1], [2]; these instruments assume the stated policy and the practised one are the same thing, an assumption our interview protocol was designed specifically to test rather than take on faith. We follow reflexive thematic analysis for coding [14], [15] and standard guidance on sample-size adequacy via saturation [16], [17] throughout. Prior work at this institution has coded interview material into a comparable taxonomy against a booking log's own official account of what a space was used for [18], and separately traced how a shared document's stated purpose drifted from the business it actually recorded after a wording refresh [19]; the present study asks the same question of an artefact with no document behind it at all, just a basket and what a household tells a visitor about it.

Method

Recruitment and sample. We recruited households that named a standing phones-in-the-basket, or equivalent physical-collection, dinner rule unprompted, via flyers left at primary-school gates, community noticeboards, and snowball referral across a mix of suburbs. Interviews continued until two independent readings of the transcripts agreed no new exception type or drift pattern was emerging [16], closing at 34 households. In 21 of the 34, a second household member who shared enforcement responsibility agreed to a separate interview, for 55 individual interviews in total; the remaining 13 households nominated a single enforcer and declined a second interview.

Interview protocol. Each 40–60 minute semi-structured interview opened with a fixed prompt — “if a visitor asked what your household's phone rule at dinner is, what would you tell them?” — recorded verbatim as the household's stated rule. The interview then worked back through the preceding fortnight's dinners meal by meal, prompting for any dinner where the rule was raised, waived, argued about, or simply not applied, without suggesting in advance what an “exception” might look like.

Coding. Transcripts were coded following reflexive thematic analysis [14], [15]. Two researchers independently open-coded a 20% subsample (11 interviews across 7 households), reconciling divergent codes into a shared codebook covering both the exception taxonomy and the drift comparison. One researcher then coded the remaining transcripts; the second independently re-coded a random 20% of the full set for a reliability check.

```
exception_pathway:
  silently_granted      # neither party names the
  rule
  formally_renegotiated # a named, time-bound
  exception
  restated_unenforced  # the rule is said aloud,
  not followed
  escalated_standing   # a repeated exception,
  now routine
drift_category: matched | loosened | reframed |
narrowed
Listing 1: Closing categories from the reconciled code-
book.
```

Reliability check. Restricting the exception taxonomy to the first coder's codes alone, rather than the reconciled double-coded subsample, changed each category's share of coded episodes by under two percentage points

(Cohen's $\kappa = .81$ on the double-coded subsample); we report the reconciled coding throughout for completeness.

Drift comparison. For each household, we compared the fixed opening recitation against the researchers' own reconstruction of the fortnight's actual practice, coding the pair as matched (the recitation still describes the fortnight observed), loosened (practice more permissive than the recitation), narrowed (practice stricter than the recitation), or reframed (the recitation's wording is unchanged, but its stated purpose no longer matches what a participant offered when asked why the rule existed in the first place).

Results

Across 34 households, we coded 212 exception episodes from the fortnight preceding each interview (Figure 1). Just under half — 44% — were silently granted: neither party named the rule, referenced an exception, or discussed the phone remaining at the table; the researcher's own follow-up question ("so is that an exception to the rule?") was, in several cases, the first time either party had framed the moment that way. Formally renegotiated exceptions — named, time-bound, and usually attached to a specific and nameable circumstance ("just for tonight, the assignment's due") — accounted for 27%. Restated-but-unenforced instances, in which the rule was invoked aloud and then not followed, made up 19%; the remaining 9% were exceptions participants described, unprompted, as having become "just what happens now" — escalated to a standing, unnamed amendment.

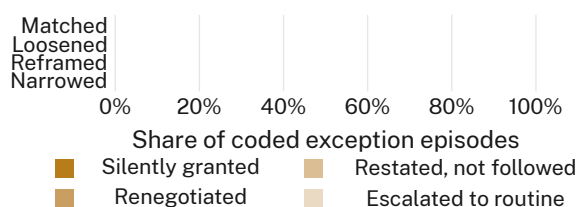


Figure 1: Within every drift category, silently-granted exceptions never fall below a fifth of coded episodes; among loosened households they make up more than half.

The drift comparison told a related but distinct story (Figure 2). Only 9 of 34 households (26%) gave a recitation that still matched the fort-

night of practice we reconstructed with them. Sixteen households (47%) had drifted toward a looser practice than their own stated rule described, almost always through the silently-granted pathway rather than any renegotiation either party could date. Six households (18%) had reframed the rule — reciting the same wording ("phones go in the basket") while offering a different justification for it than the one a family member remembered giving at the rule's outset, most often moving from a stated concern about distraction to a stated concern about modelling behaviour for younger children. The remaining three households (9%) had narrowed practice beyond what their own recitation required, generally following a specific incident neither party had folded back into how they described the rule to a visitor.



Figure 2: Households (n = 34) by drift category: fewer than three in ten recited a rule that still matched the fortnight of practice we reconstructed against it.

Matched households were not distinguishable by rule age, household size, or the age of the youngest child; the strongest pattern in our data, such as it is, was that households whose stated rule referenced a specific originating occasion — a doctor's warning, a bad dinner, a sibling's diagnosis — were somewhat more likely to fall in the reframed category than households whose stated rule offered no origin story at all, though our sample is too small to treat this as more than a direction for a larger study.

Discussion

The households in our sample rarely experienced their own rule drift as a decision. A recitation that no longer matched practice was, in most cases, not defended, contested, or even noticed until the interview's own back-and-forth surfaced it; the rule's language had simply kept doing its job — settling a visitor's question, closing the school-newsletter conversation about screen time — while the practice it described moved on without it. This sits com-

fortably alongside a broader institutional-theory account of formal structures that persist for their legitimacy value once daily activity has decoupled from them [6], [7], scaled down here to a household with one basket and one recurring argument about whose turn it is to notice. It also speaks to a wider pattern this School has traced in larger institutions, where a priority's language survives well past the conditions that first justified it [19]. What our interviews cannot tell us is whether a household that renamed or re-recited its rule mid-drift would enforce the update any more consistently than the version it replaced; we take up why that question resists a further round of the same method in Limitations.

Limitations

Our sample recruited households that already named a phones-in-the-basket rule unprompted, which excludes households that enforce an equivalent norm without a name for it, and any household without such a norm at all; if anything, a named rule should be the version most resistant to unmarked drift, since it has a form to drift away from. A single retrospective interview cannot rule out reconstruction error in either the recitation or the fortnight it is checked against, though the 21 households with two independently interviewed members showed close agreement on both without prior coordination, which we take as some reassurance that recall, rather than fabrication, is the operative risk. Thirty-four households is a modest base for the reframed and narrowed categories specifically; both held up under the coding reliability check regardless.

Conclusion

A household's phones-in-the-basket rule survives, in most cases, as a form of words rather than as a fixed description of what happens at dinner. Most of that survival is unremarkable: an exception granted without a conversation, absorbed rather than negotiated, until the household's own account of its rule is a few months behind the table it governs. Only a quarter of the households we interviewed could recite a rule that still matched their own recent practice, and almost none had noticed the gap before we asked about it directly. Future work might test whether naming the drift back to a household changes anything about how the rule is subsequently enforced, or whether — like the

language this School studies elsewhere — the recitation would simply absorb the correction and carry on unchanged.

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